Enterprise Student Record and Academic Management Platform

Unit - 1 Mini Project: Design Thinking, Product Engineering & Agile Planning

STUDENT & PROJECT METADATA

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Course / Unit: DevOps Engineering - Unit 1: Product Engineering & Design Thinking

Project Title: Enterprise Student Record and Academic Management Platform

Submission Date: August 19, 2026

1. Executive Summary & Objective

This document serves as the formal Unit-1 Mini Project deliverable for the Enterprise Student Record and Academic Management Platform. Modern software engineering requires transitioning from ad-hoc programming to structured, human-centered product engineering frameworks. The objective of this project is to independently apply Design Thinking, IBM Enterprise Design Thinking principles, domain analysis, and product planning to design a scalable, cloud-native higher education academic platform before writing code.

By establishing a robust foundation comprising Business Requirements Documents (BRD), User Personas, Functional/Non-Functional Specifications, System Architecture, and Agile Project Plans, this project prepares the platform for seamless execution in subsequent DevOps, CI/CD, and Cloud Infrastructure units.

2. Introduction to Software Product Development

2.1 Comparative Analysis: Programming vs. Software Product Engineering

Software product development differs fundamentally from isolated coding activities. The table below outlines key dimensions separating traditional programming from modern product engineering:

Dimension	Programming / Coding	Software Product Engineering
Primary Goal	Translating logic/algorithms into executable code syntax.	Building scalable, maintainable, and valuable enterprise systems.
Scope	Isolated functions, micro-tasks, or single	Full Software Development Lifecycle

	standalone scripts.	(SDLC), architecture, CI/CD, schemas.
Success Metric	Code compiles successfully and passes standard test inputs.	User adoption, high availability, performance metrics, business outcome.
Mindset	Technology-Centric ("How do I write this function?").	Product-Centric ("What core problem are we solving for our users?").

2.2 Root Causes of Software Project Failures

Enterprise software initiatives rarely fail due to technical syntax errors. Analysis of industry failure vectors reveals primary failure causes:

- **Misaligned Requirements:** Building complex features that end-users do not require or desire due to inadequate preliminary research.
- **Technology-Centric Bias:** Selecting tools and frameworks based on industry trends rather than technical fit for domain problems.
- **Communication Silos:** Organizational distance between business managers, software developers, and operational engineers.
- **Lack of Iterative Feedback:** Delaying user evaluation until late deployment stages, rendering architectural pivots prohibitively expensive.

2.3 Visual Lifecycle: Software Development Lifecycle (SDLC)

The platform adheres to a structured, 6-stage engineering lifecycle model:

- 1. Requirement Gathering & Domain Analysis (Business understanding, stakeholder expectations)
- 2. Design Thinking & User Experience (UX) Wireframing (Empathy mapping, prototyping)
- 3. System Architecture & Database Schema Design (Microservices, relational constraints)
- 4. Implementation & Coding Phase (~20% Total Effort - Backend APIs, Frontend interfaces)
- 5. Automated CI/CD, DevOps Pipeline & Testing (Unit, integration, automated testing)
- 6. Production Deployment, Observability & Feedback Loop (Kubernetes, Grafana monitoring)

3. Business Understanding & Domain Analysis

3.1 Academic Management Operations

Higher education institutions require precise management across key academic verticals:

- **Student Admissions:** Managing student onboarding, verification, identity document uploads, and roll assignment.
- **Course Registration:** Handling course catalogs, pre-requisite validations, elective allocations, and enrollment quotas.
- **Attendance Management:** Tracking daily session attendance, calculating eligibility thresholds, and flagging low attendance.

- **Examinations & Results:** Conducting examinations, invigilation scheduling, grading, and transcript compilation.

3.2 Manual Operational Bottlenecks vs. Automated Platform Solutions

Manual Operational Bottleneck	Automated Platform Solution	Business Outcome Metric
Paper-based student admission & registration forms	Centralized online portal with automated validation	Processing time reduced from 14 days to <10 minutes
Manual attendance marking in physical register books	Automated digital attendance tracking with portal access	Classroom queue/overhead reduced by 85%
Manual calculation of GPA/CGPA and paper report cards	Automated grade processing engine and digital transcripts	Transcript generation accelerated by 95% (instant)
Inaccurate physical files, lost records, data duplication	Relational database with strict referential integrity	Data accuracy & integrity raised to 99.99%

4. Design Thinking Framework

The platform design utilizes the five-stage human-centered Design Thinking model:

4.1 Stage 1: Empathize

Conducted contextual inquiries and qualitative interviews with higher education stakeholders (students, faculty, administrators, exam staff). Identified major friction points around delayed grade updates, opaque attendance tracking, and cumbersome manual registration.

4.2 Stage 2: Define

Core Problem Statement Definition: Synthesized user research into a centralized, actionable problem statement:

> *"Students and faculty members in higher education face severe delays, record inaccuracies, and administrative overhead due to fragmented manual and legacy systems for course registration, attendance tracking, and grade publication. Concurrently, academic administrators lack real-time visibility into operational analytics, degrading institutional efficiency and user satisfaction."*

4.3 Stage 3: Ideate

Brainstormed multi-tiered software capabilities focused on automation and user empowerment: dynamic self-service course registration, real-time attendance tracking via mobile, automated GPA engines, instant push/email alerts, and executive analytics dashboards.

4.4 Stage 4: Prototype

Developed low-fidelity wireframes and layout flows for four key modules: Student Dashboard, Faculty Attendance/Grade Portal, Exam Cell Management Hub, and Administrator Analytics Panel.

4.5 Stage 5: Test

Evaluated prototypes through walkthroughs with sample user groups. Iterated UX layouts to minimize click paths, resulting in sub-3-click navigation for critical student and faculty workflows.

5. Enterprise Design Thinking & IBM Loop Execution

5.1 IBM Design Thinking Principles

- **Focus on User Outcomes:** Shifting technical objectives toward human value. Instead of 'Build a database for grades', the outcome focus is 'Allow students to view semester results within 2 seconds of official release.'
- **Restless Reinvention:** Treating deployment as a continuous cycle of enhancement, leveraging telemetry and user feedback to refine UI and performance.
- **Diverse Empowered Teams:** Fostering cross-functional collaboration across Product Managers, Full-Stack Developers, UX Designers, QA Engineers, and DevOps Engineers.

5.2 IBM Loop Framework: Observe → Reflect → Make

- **Observe:** Gather operational telemetry, conduct user surveys, and analyze audit logs to identify friction in course drop/add workflows.
- **Reflect:** Analyze performance metrics, align stakeholder priorities, evaluate backlog items, and re-architect underperforming modules.
- **Make:** Develop modular REST APIs, craft responsive UI interfaces, and automate CI/CD pipeline deployments.

6. Stakeholder Analysis & User Personas

6.1 Stakeholder Matrix

Stakeholder Group	Key Roles	Responsibilities & Expectations
Business Stakeholders	College Management, Deans, Academic Council	Define institutional vision, ensure regulatory compliance, validate operational ROI.
Engineering Stakeholders	Software Developers, UX Designers, QA Team	Architect microservices, build accessible UIs, ensure code quality and unit test coverage.
Operations Stakeholders	DevOps Engineers, DBAs, Security Operations	Provision cloud infrastructure, execute CI/CD, maintain 99.9% availability,

safeguard PII data.

6.2 User Persona Development

User Persona	Primary Objectives	Frustrations & Pain Points	Target Platform Feature
Aarav Sharma (Student)	Register for courses quickly; track real-time attendance and grades.	Long physical registration queues; unexpected exam disqualifications due to attendance loss.	Mobile self-service portal, real-time attendance tracker, automated notifications.
Dr. Rajesh Verma (Faculty Member)	Log attendance efficiently; enter student grades; review class performance.	Manual paper registers; repetitive grade compilation; lack of automated summary stats.	One-click digital attendance, automated GPA calculation, class roster analytics.
Prof. Sunita Patel (Academic Administrator)	Monitor institutional metrics; approve registrations; generate compliance reports.	Fragmented data siloes; manual paper report generation taking multiple days.	Centralized executive dashboard, real-time data integration, 1-click PDF reporting.

7. Requirements Engineering Specification

7.1 Functional Requirements Specification (FRS)

- **FR-01 Authentication & RBAC:** Secure authentication utilizing JWT tokens and Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) for Admin, Faculty, Student, and Exam Cell roles.
- **FR-02 Course Registration:** Self-service registration portal enforcing course prerequisites, seat capacity limits, and schedule collision checks.
- **FR-03 Attendance Tracking:** Interface for faculty to record daily session attendance with automated threshold monitoring and alert triggers.
- **FR-04 Examination & Result Engine:** Automated grade entry, GPA/CGPA calculation engine, and secure transcript generation.
- **FR-05 Report Generation:** Dynamic generation of institutional compliance reports, departmental transcripts, and audit logs with PDF/Excel exports.

7.2 Non-Functional Requirements Specification (NFRS)

- **NFR-01 Security & Data Protection:** Password hashing using Argon2/Bcrypt, TLS 1.3 encryption for data in transit, AES-256 for data at rest, and OWASP Top 10 compliance.
- **NFR-02 Performance & Response Time:** API response times under 300ms for 95% of requests under a concurrent load of 2,000 active users.

- **NFR-03 High Availability & Reliability:** Containerized microservices targeted for 99.9% operational uptime with automatic failover and multi-zone database redundancy.
- **NFR-04 Maintainability & Scalability:** Infrastructure as Code (IaC) using Terraform, automated CI/CD pipelines, modular repository setup, and clear technical documentation.

8. Product Vision, MVP Scope & Product Roadmap

8.1 Product Vision & Mission Statements

Vision Statement: To empower higher education institutions with a modern, cloud-native Academic Management Platform that eliminates administrative overhead, enhances operational transparency, and provides a seamless digital academic experience.

Mission Statement: To deliver a secure, reliable, and user-centric platform integrating student lifecycle operations into a single ecosystem driven by automated workflows and real-time analytics.

8.2 Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Scope (Sprints 1 - 4)

To achieve rapid market validation and early deployment, non-essential advanced features (such as AI grade predictions or external fee payment integration) are deferred to later releases. The MVP core scope includes:

- User Authentication & Profile RBAC (Student, Faculty, Admin)
- Basic Student Onboarding & Record Management
- Course Catalog & Digital Registration Module
- Faculty Attendance Logging & Student Threshold Alerts
- Basic Result Generation & Transcript Export Module

8.3 Multi-Phase Enterprise Product Engineering Roadmap

- Phase 1: Domain Analysis, Design Thinking & Product Vision (Unit 1)
- Phase 2: Agile Backlog Creation, User Story Mapping & Architecture Design
- Phase 3: Core Application Backend Development (RESTful Microservices & Database Schemas)
- Phase 4: Responsive Frontend Development & API Integration
- Phase 5: DevOps Automation (CI/CD Pipelines, GitHub Actions, Containerization)
- Phase 6: Infrastructure Automation (Terraform Provisioning & Ansible Configuration)
- Phase 7: Production Deployment, Kubernetes Orchestration & Observability (Prometheus/Grafana)

9. System Architecture & Repository Initialization

9.1 Standardized Project Folder Structure

The project codebase is organized following industry-standard monorepo practices suitable for microservices and DevOps automation:

```
student-academic-platform/
├── .github/              # CI/CD Workflows (GitHub Actions Pipelines)
├── app/                  # Application Source Code
│   ├── modules/          # Core Business Logic (Admissions, Courses, Attendance, Results)
│   ├── database/         # Database Schemas, Migrations, & ORM Models
│   └── tests/            # Automated Unit, Integration, & End-to-End Tests
├── docs/                 # Architecture Diagrams, BRD, FRS/NFRS Specs, & Design Thinking
Reports
├── docker/               # Dockerfiles & Multi-Container Docker-Compose Setup
├── kubernetes/           # K8s Manifests (Deployments, Services, Ingress, ConfigMaps)
├── terraform/            # Cloud Infrastructure as Code (IaC) Provisioning Scripts
├── ansible/              # Configuration Management Playbooks & Server Setup
├── monitoring/           # Prometheus Metrics & Grafana Dashboard Configurations
└── README.md             # Project Onboarding, Architecture Guide, & Setup Instructions
```

10. Deliverables Checklist & Verification

All required deliverables outlined in the assignment specification have been completed and verified:

- [X] Business Requirements Document (BRD) & Justification Report
- [X] Product Vision Statement & MVP Scope Definition Matrix
- [X] Stakeholder Responsibility Matrix & User Persona Profiles
- [X] Functional (FRS) & Non-Functional (NFRS) Requirements Specs
- [X] Design Thinking Execution Report (Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, Test)
- [X] IBM Enterprise Design Thinking & IBM Loop Documentation
- [X] Multi-Phase Enterprise Engineering Product Roadmap
- [X] System Architecture Concept Specs & Monorepo Repository Structure
- [X] Initialized Project Workspace & Git Repository Structure